DRUM CARE AND MAINTENANCE

With proper care and maintenance, a drum should give long lasting performance. Environmental conditions playa key role in maintaining a healthy drum. Optimal conditions for a drum are temperatures between 69 to 78 degrees, with moderate' humidity. It takes practice to know what a 4rum needs to keep it in a range of good tone. I encourage drum owners to develop a relationship with a drum, just as you would with a person or pet. Each drum has its own personality.

High temperatures are a drum's worst enemy. Heat, accompanied by low humidity can ruin a drum. The drum will tighten and the pitch will increase above 78 degrees. A drum exposed to dry temperatures of 90 degrees or more for long periods will suffer damage. Overexposure to high temperatures or any direct heat source will tighten the skin and cause the lacing to break and or the wood to warp. If a drum becomes overheated, you can quickly cool it down by splashing water on the skin and lacing or placing a wet cloth or towel around it. Test the tone until it reaches the comfort zone. Moderate amounts of water will not harm the drum unless it becomes soggy or remains wet for an extended time.

An ideal way to travel with your drum in hot weather is to place it in a plastic bag along with a wet cloth tucked into a zip lock bag with the top open. Seal the drum and open zip lock bag inside the plastic bag. This will keep moisture around the drum, keeping it relatively safe from the heat.

Humidity affects the tone. Dry air tightens the skin; moist air loosens it. If humidity dampens your drum to a dull tone, bring it into a warm room or place it in sunlight or near another heat source to tighten the skin. Test the drum periodically until it reaches the desired tone. **Never overexposing your drum to any heat source.**

Clean your drum by sponging it off with warm soppy water then letting it dry in a warm environment. In time, a drum will need to be relaced or reskinned, procedures best left to a drum maker. If maintained with care, however, a drum should last many years before requiring anything other than an occasional cleaning.

This drum has been constructed to tolerate sweat lodge conditions. While you will find that the heat and humidity in a sweat lodge will dampen the tone, you can adjust it by holding it over the hot rocks in the lodge, paying attention to the skin and rising tone and being careful not overexpose it to the heat. Keep in mind that high heat accompanied by dry conditions will damage this drum just as it would any other drum, so you must protect it as described above from these conditions.

Aho Mitakuye Oyasin

Tony